

Lifelines of National Economy

Social Science — Geography • Chapter 7 • Chapter Summary & Study Guide for Daksh

Imagine a postal letter you posted in Delhi reaching Chennai in two days; a banana from Karnataka reaching Punjab in three; a software request from Bengaluru being served from a US data centre in milliseconds. None of these would be possible without efficient **transport, communication and trade**. They are truly the **lifelines of the national economy** — moving goods, people, information and money.

Transport — the means of moving goods and people

Transport is land, water or air-based:

- **Roadways** — India has one of the largest road networks in the world (~63 lakh km). Types: Golden Quadrilateral & North-South, East-West Corridors (Super-fast); National Highways (NH-1 Delhi-Amritsar, NH-7 longest till 2010 — Varanasi-Kanyakumari); State Highways; District & Village roads; Border Roads (BRO — strategic, in NE/Himalayas).
- **Railways** — backbone of India's transport. World's 4th largest network. Convenient for long distances, large freight, mass passenger transport. Indian Railways now has electric/diesel locomotives, Vande Bharat semi-high-speed trains, dedicated freight corridors.
- **Pipelines** — efficient for transporting crude oil, gas, water; e.g. HBJ pipeline (Hazira-Bijaipur-Jagdishpur).
- **Waterways** — cheapest mode but slow. Inland: NW-1 Allahabad-Haldia (Ganga); NW-2 Sadiya-Dhubri (Brahmaputra); NW-3 (Kerala backwaters). Major sea-ports: Mumbai, JNPT, Kandla, Kochi, Chennai, Vizag, Paradip, Haldia, Tuticorin.
- **Airways** — fast, can reach difficult terrain (NE, J&K). Domestic and international flights; major airlines now mostly private; Air India was the national carrier.

Communication — the link of the modern world

Communication has gone from postcards to instant chat:

- **Personal communication:** post, telegram (closed in 2013), telephones (landlines now declining), mobile phones, internet, social media.
- **Mass communication:** newspapers, magazines, radio (All India Radio), TV (Doordarshan, private channels), films, internet.
- Indian newspapers are published in over 100 languages. Films industry — second-largest in the world.

International trade — the engine of growth

Trade is exchange of goods/services. Domestic trade happens within a country; **international trade** between countries. **Balance of trade** = value of exports minus value of imports. Favourable when exports > imports.

- **India's exports:** agro and allied (rice, spices, tea, coffee, cotton, marine products), engineering goods, ores and minerals (iron ore), petroleum products, gems and jewellery, chemicals and pharmaceuticals, textiles, IT services.
- **India's imports:** petroleum and crude oil (single largest item), machinery, electronics, gold and silver, fertilisers, chemicals, edible oils.
- Trading partners: USA, China, UAE, Saudi Arabia, Singapore, Hong Kong, Germany, UK.

Tourism — invisible exports

Tourism is one of India's fastest-growing service industries. It earns valuable foreign exchange, generates employment (over 8.7 million people directly employed by 2010), and promotes national integration. Categories: heritage (Taj Mahal, Khajuraho, Hampi), business, eco (Sundarban, Kerala backwaters), adventure (Ladakh, Himalaya), medical (low-cost surgeries with global standards), cultural, beach (Goa). Foreign tourist arrivals show steady growth — but India remains underutilised; further investment in infrastructure can unlock much more potential.

How transport, communication and trade tie everything together

These three are deeply interlinked. A fertiliser factory needs raw material to be transported in (rail/pipe/ship), produces fertiliser that goes to farmers (rail/road), helps grow more wheat (sold via traders), exports may follow — but every step needs communication (orders, payments, market prices, weather forecasts). When any one of these slows down, the entire economy feels it — like blocked arteries.

★ MUST-REMEMBER POINTS

- Roadways: Golden Quadrilateral, NH/SH/District/Village/Border roads.
- Railways: world's 4th largest. Coal/iron ore freight & passenger movement.
- Pipelines (oil/gas/water) – e.g. HBJ pipeline.
- Major ports: Mumbai, Kandla, Chennai, Vizag, Kochi, Tuticorin, Paradip, Haldia, JNPT.
- Inland waterways: NW-1 Ganga, NW-2 Brahmaputra, NW-3 Kerala backwaters.
- Communication: post, mobile, internet; newspapers in 100+ languages; films second-largest industry.
- Trade balance = exports – imports. Tourism = foreign-exchange + jobs + culture.

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